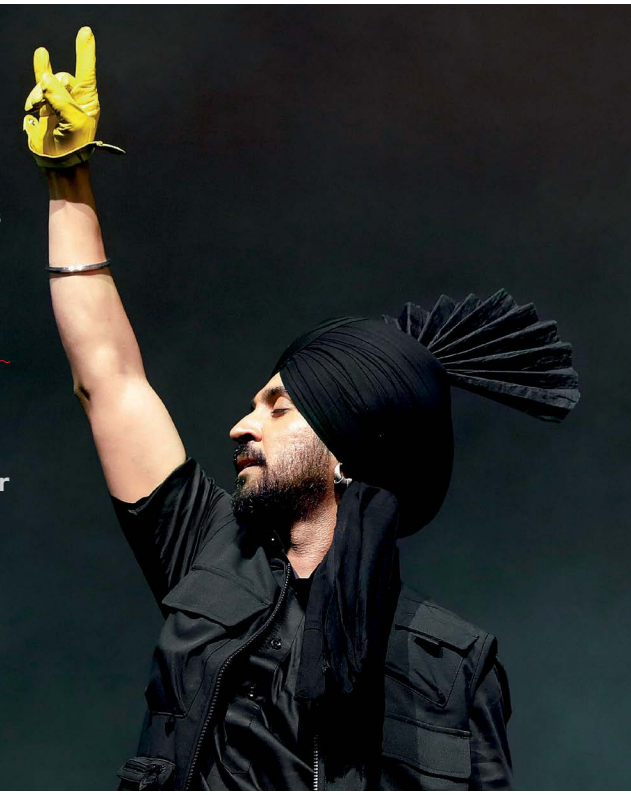
Born to Shine

- Among India's most successful pop culture exports, Diljit Dosanjh regaled audiences across America, Europe and Australia during his 'Dil-Luminati' tour
- Even performed two of his songs–'Born to Shine' and 'G.O.A.T.'–on the American late-night show hosted by Jimmy Fallon
- Back home, he broke linguistic barriers, performing in jam-packed venues across India, and set off a trend of similar concert tours by other Punjabi artistes
- A fine actor, Diljit wowed audiences with his portrayal of Punjabi musician Amar Singh Chamkila in the eponymous biopic on Netflix; also broke box-office records with the third instalment of his Punjabi rom-com *Jatt & Juliet*



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he's the rare north Indian artiste whose music transcends linguistic barriers, with even non-Punjabis singing along, word for word. And he has this ability to strike a chord with audiences anywhere in India, even while conversing in a mix of Punjabi and Hindi. That's the reason why, by the end of Dil-Luminati's successful run, his chant "*Main Hoon Punjab*" (I am Punjab) had become a powerful declaration as much as a sartorial statement.

All year round, Diljit turned heads the way only he can. In an election year when there was no escaping divisive politics, he showed why art is the great unifier. "*Punjabiyan de dilan ich sabde layi pyar ae* (There is love for all in the hearts of every Punjabi)," he said after gifting his shoes to a Pakistani fan at a concert in Manchester, UK. Back in India, he 'politely' called out state governments for moral policing and notices that had warned him to avoid songs glorifying drugs and alcohol. When social media was flooded with posts decrying poor concert infrastructure, he too backed his fans, even warning that he'd stop performing in India unless the situation was rectified.

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In the crowded entertainment ecosystem where it often becomes hard to separate one voice from another, Diljit is an all-rounder, an artiste who regales the audience with his talent, persona and chutzpah. The American late-night talk show host Jimmy Fallon called him "the biggest Punjabi artiste on the planet" as Diljit tried to teach him a word or two in his mother tongue.

Plucky but without being outwardly anti-establishment and offensive, Diljit won hearts not just as a singer but even as an actor. His portrayal of Amar Singh Chamkila in Imtiaz Ali's eponymous Netflix film was pitch perfect, channelling the artist's humanity as much as his innate talent and sincerity towards his art. Back home in Punjab, he broke box-office records with the third instalment of his 12-year-old romantic comedy franchise *Jatt & Juliet*.

Diljit may not have featured in Spotify's most streamed artist or even the song list for 2024, but his peppy playlist kept crowds on their feet—at concerts, house parties and weddings. His success is proof that art without artifice sells. It's why one can't help but root for Diljit. ■